Challenging authorities: a postcolonial interactive exhibition codesigned by Namibian born-frees

Asnath Paula Kambunga, Rachel Charlotte Smith
Aarhus University
{akambunga, rsmith} @cc.au.dk

Heike Winschiers-Theophilus, Peter Wandai, Holger Antonio,
Namutenya Shalumbu, David Muronga
Namibia University of Science and Technology
hwinschiers@nust.na, peter@kalaharitech.co.za,holggerjose@gmail.com, shalumbun@telecom.na, dmuronga@hotmail.com

Peter Kaulbach
Hochschule Flensburg
peter_kaulbach@hotmail.de

Veera Virmasalo,
Malmö University, Sweden
veera.virmasalo@mau.se

Abstract

Even though public participation and using interactive technologies in museums is becoming popular around the world, museums in Namibia have not yet embraced interactive and emerging technologies to enhance participation, support meaningful interactions or attract visitors. The Independence Memorial Museum (IMM) in Windhoek Namibia, which houses the colonial history of Namibia, more specifically the German colonial era and the liberation struggle from South Africa [WiMa19] is a classic example of authoritarian and traditional curation: maintaining an obvious bias towards the colonial history, displaying monumental huge wall paintings, still images of past struggle and artefacts from the colonial period with textual descriptions in English over three floors. In this paper, we present an interactive exhibition on postcolonial narratives of the born frees which was co-designed with a group 10 youth and 5 interaction design students. The exhibition challenged traditional curation methods, introduced the youth voices in a traditional museum whose voices provoked the postcolonial narratives by addressing everyday experiences and issues relating to education, languages, economics and indigenous knowledge.

Introduction

Creating interactions and increasing visitor's participation in museums has over the years attracted researchers and designers within the field of Human Computer Interaction. Research in museum and heritage work has focused on designing for participation [DaDE08], enhancing the experiences of visitors [KBCB04], involving different stakeholders in the design process and engaging youth and museum audiences in dialogic discussions to contribute to the design of future museum experiences [SmIv14], [SmOt16].

Participation in museums through technology has also been used to address power structures in museums, in which traditionally curators decide what goes into the exhibition [Simo10]. Participatory design approaches applied during the design of interactive installations and used to engage the audience during the exhibition allowed visitors to interpret the exhibition, creating new meaning and creating heritage in the process [SmIv14], [Giac12].

Though there is a significant shift in engaging community members in museums around the world, this has not been the case for Namibia. However, there has been a series of events on museum conversations, problematising issues on how museums can be more inclusive, and discussing visions for the future of African museums [Muco19]. This type of events can be seen as a good way of creating consciousness among the curators, and community members on addressing issues such as power, and using contextualised methods for encouraging participation.

To attract more visitors and enhance experiences, a couple of interactive prototypes were previously designed for the Independence Memorial Museum, such as location-aware interactive guide app [KaHS16], a virtual welcome guide [WeMM14], and persuasive souvenirs [MuOM14], yet they were never installed in the museum. For us, the Independence Memorial Museum was the perfect context for an experimental interactive exhibition, to challenge and infuse life into the authoritative and normative representations of Namibian colonial past. The exhibition was conceptualised with Namibian 'born-frees'; young people born after independence in 1990, whose voices are not normally part of the contemporary public debates on the past, and as a way of creating a wider discourse on postcolonialism. In this paper, we briefly describe the six-month co-design process with 10 born-frees and 5 interaction design students led by a born-free PhD candidate, supported by a Professor in Interaction Design as well as PhD candidate in media and communication studies exploring how social justice ideas are communicated to and by middle classes. It resulted in a two-weeks public interactive exhibition consisting of three distinct

augmented reality installations, one soundscape, one overlay photo booth, a raspberry-pi phone creating contexts and opportunities for embodied engagement.

Namibian Context

The Republic of Namibia is one of the last countries to attain its independence from external colonial forces in 1990 [Saun17]. Namibia's dual colonial history started late 19th century, when Namibia was colonised by the German empire from 1884-1914. This colonial era was mostly remembered for the genocide of the Herero and Nama people and the signing of land treaties with the locals [Köss15], [Melb19]. After the German colonial era, Namibia was put under the administration of South Africa, of which the south African government applied apartheid laws to segregate people based on race [Saun17]. Other significant happenings during the south African apartheid is the resistance and fight for freedom by South West Africa People's Organisation (SWAPO) [Silv15]. Today, significant events of colonialism are commemorated and memories of colonialism are preserved and presented in different forms. The colonial history of Namibia is exhibited in the Independence Memorial Museum, a landmark standing tall between 'Christuskirche' and 'Alte Fest' fort [Beck18]. The exhibition halls inside the museum are filled with artefacts, huge wall paintings, some with descriptions written in small letters and some lacking descriptions [WiMa19].

The young people of Namibia, born after independence do not have first-hand colonial experiences but see traces ingrained in contemporary cityscapes, infrastructures, processes and people [Köss15], [Silv15]. They witness ongoing post-colonial debates, such as the 1904 genocide repatriation, and the land reform, as a legacy of colonial misappropriation of land. Today, postcolonial discourses barely contain the voices of the youth, as they are considered too young or with no experiences on issues that relate to colonialism.

Methodology

In our design process, we merged components from two pragmatic methodological approaches to engage the youth and students. We used approaches from design anthropology which are instrumental in understanding cultural realities of the youth being designed with, and also preeminent in designing alternative futures [GuOS13]. Secondly, we used localised Participatory

Design methods to co-design technologies, whereby all team members had a say in the design process to achieve the set goals and visions [WCKB10], [WiBB12], [SeSm12]

In May 2019, we conducted individual ethnographic interviews, to enquire into the cultural realities and to recruit the youth, who were either active in social media postcolonial discourses, in youth led organisations or known otherwise to the researchers. In the first workshop with all the youth, we set individual and common goals to be achieved within 6 months [GoKW18]. The youth stated that as 'agents to bridge today for tomorrow' they would create an exhibition to engage more people and to display their everyday postcolonial experiences. Among others they expressed their frustration of being excluded from postcolonial discourses, and how the '*comrades'* (a term politicians in Namibia use, mostly for those who were present during colonial times) feel entitled to drive the narratives. Thus, the youth argued that an exhibition could provoke postcolonial discussions while showing appreciation for the past.

To situate our exhibition, we explored the IMM and identified gaps in the current exhibits. The youth discovered that the museum lacks interactivity, voices of young people and women, everyday memories and experiences of ordinary Namibians, descriptions on some artefacts and the unavailability of curators to engage with the youth. The exhibitions are mainly glorifying the ruling party which fought for the liberation struggle against the South Africans.

The research team and youth conducted a series of workshop sessions to problematize the current issues relating to postcolonialism. Recordings of these sessions were used in the exhibition's soundscape. While the youth complained not having had a safe space to freely discuss those issues, they also felt surrounded by 'noise', oversaturated with meaningless information on social media and certain voices louder than others. This analysis fuelled the desire to create a public exhibition, thereby creating new meanings to initiate a new postcolonial narrative including minority voices. At this point the interaction design students joined the team. The students were mostly responsible for the technical aspects while the youth focused on the content. However, in the sessions all parties involved contributed to the design of the individual exhibits and the visitors' flow through the exhibitions.

Postcolonial Narratives of the born-frees an interactive tech exhibition

The exhibition was launched on 21 October 2019 outside the Independence Memorial Museum, with a number of invited delegates and the media. The event was broadcasted during the news

sections, printed in the newspapers and aired on radio. The launch programme broke protocols in terms of speaking slots only attributed to the creators and not dignitaries. It is to be noted that the launch of the exhibition preceded the 2019 election, which by some politicians was interpreted as a direct provocation of the government.

The exhibition consisted of themes that the visitor was channelled through in a singular possible path. The first installation at the entrance was a soundscape, which represented the current state of confusion, playing a mixture of born-free voices all at the same time, with some being heard more than others. It provided control stations where voices can be amplified or silenced. To understand the present better and why things are the way they are, visitors were channelled into the "Learning from the past" section. The visitors experienced sharing of indigenous knowledge around a projected fire as well as attempts to make sense of the past through an augmented reality technology puzzle. Appealing to the wish expressed by some born-frees to have been part of the liberation struggle, a photo booth took the visitor right back in time by taking a picture with freedom fighters or war themed backgrounds. On the path to the future section, visitors were reminded of the necessity to take actions to create better futures, by crossing a bridge. On this path, visitors could also listen to how languages remind the youth of colonialism, at the phonebooth. The road to the future also presented economic challenges as observed by the born-frees, which were presented in an augmented reality room for social justice [AsAV18]. Finally, in the future section, we engaged the visitors in answering questions on the wall, as a means of creating participatory and inclusive futures. The visitors also got to reflect on the exhibition, and future imaginations by playing interactive games. The interactive installations are explained in details below.

Present sections

Soundscape

The soundscape was set up in a 4*8 meter tent (as a way to contain the noise from the other parts of the exhibition). We used board dividers to create a maze-like feature, with some hidden dead-end to confuse the visitors and create a narrative that illustrates the confusion state. Light emitting diodes LEDs, were installed on the base of the boards, which provided illumination to the

installation. Along the boards in intervals of 2 meters dressed up mannequins were placed to give the impression the voices emanate from them.

The installation was designed to cater for a sound-based user experience from which audio projections were meshed up per device in order for multiple voices to play at the same time or individually. The users were able to control the voices on an iPad, which was running the Unity game engine. Two iPad devices were placed in different sections of the soundscape installation. Each iPad was connected to 2 x subwoofers and 4 small speakers, concealed at the base of the tent. This layout was intended to not only create a surround sound, but also ensure that the audio projections for each device meshes with others to create one chaotic sound when all audios are playing simultaneously.

Once the museum audience enters the exhibition, they could hear multiple voices playing at the same time. The iPad prompted people to mute some of the voices, by tapping on the picture of the youth on the screen. The youth who were available in the exhibition halls did not have to explain a lot on how the technology works, but rather engaged the audience in discussing the topics being addressed in the recordings relating to the usage of slang languages and their relation to languages used during the colonial times to confuse the colonisers. Some recordings related to how the education system is still colonising; having the bible translated into local languages but not the science books. In the recordings the youth have also addressed issues relating to how lack of consciousness among community members is like permanent enslavement.

Fig. 1: Inside the soundscape room © A.P Kambunga

Telephone booth

For the phone booth installation, we used an old Analog phone, which was reprogrammed with a raspberry pi. The intention was to show how colonial languages are at times considered as business language in public and private offices, and how some people use indigenous languages in public offices instead of the official language -English. The visitors engaged with the installation by calling specific numbers and listening to audios, such as a dentist receptionist speaking in Afrikaans with a patient, instead of English; a police officer insulting a young person for speaking in English when they surely speak the same indigenous knowledge.

Fig. 2: Telephone booth on the left and room for social justice on the right. © A.P Kambunga

The "room for social justice"

The Room for Social Justice contrasted the wealth and poverty that exist side by side in Namibia, which remains one of the most unequal counties in the world [WoBa18]. The installation was constructed with two walls, a painted wall symbolising an upmarket house in the wealthy suburbs and a corrugated iron wall representing the shacks in the other side of the city. The walls featured images portraying social challenges the young curators had identified as most pressing for post-colonial Namibia. These images functioned as augmented reality markers the visitors could scan using an application installed on an android phone. Each scan would open video content on the phone screen and connected headphones, challenging the visitor to reflect on the various issues. The visitors also had to choose between potential solutions to the problems and to indicate their choice by donating play money to their chosen solution. Finally, a mirror hanging on the wealthy wall triggered augmented content, which asked the visitor to reflect on what they themselves were doing about the challenges by acting – or not acting – as "responsible" citizens.

The visitors' reactions to the Room may be characterised by dividing them into two groups. One group, comprising mainly young visitors, were mostly interested in augmented reality technology. When prompted to comment on the content, most reacted in a cynical manner, saying that they were tired of hearing about the same problems all the time and were not interested in talking more about them - especially since the decision-makers, in their view, were not getting anything done about the problems in any case. Another group, comprising mainly of visitors in their 40s and above, were focused on the content from the onset, some criticising it as portraying the country in a manner that was too negative and some engaging in lively debates about possible solutions.

Past section

Augmented reality of indigenous knowledge

The indigenous knowledge installation was created for people to learn from the rich indigenous knowledge shared orally by elders in rural areas. The installation was set up with dressed up mannequins and traditional objects around a fire, resembling Namibian traditional homes fireplaces. The burning fire was projected on a wall with a projector and the visitors sat on logs (traditional chairs). The visitor used an android mobile phone to scan markers which were placed on a traditional pottery. Each marker was embedded with stories from indigenous elders telling stories relating to using traditional medicine, hunting, and analysing animal carcases. The scenario

was to simulate the “talking to the ancestors" who share their wisdom with us. While the IMM focused on the liberation struggle and its pre and post-era, at no point does it acknowledge the country’s vast richness in indigenous knowledge.

Fig. 3: Audience at the indigenous knowledge installation left, and making sense of past right. © A.P Kambunga

Making sense of the past installation

The visitors interacted with the AR puzzle installation by moving the markers, printed on magnets, around on the Namibian map and placing them on the right spot. After placing the marker on the map, the visitors scanned the marker using an android mobile phone, and if placed in the right spot, a video plaid showing the cultural reality of the ethnic groups, else an error was displayed. If some markers were placed together, they showed the relationship between the two ethnic groups, for example the nama-herero war. This installation was more of an educational game as well, allowing people to play and learn about Namibian ethnic groups by placing the magnets in the right spots. The application was coded using C#, and used Unity game engine and Vuforia for the backbone. Inside the exhibition, the application required extra lighting because the room was quite dark. We have experienced the same issue with other apps used for the IK installation and the social justice room as well.

The photobooth

The photobooth installation used dslrBooth (professional edition) to enable the audience to take pictures with backgrounds from the colonial times and or with some of the late early colonial resistance leaders such as captain Hendrik Witbooi. The installation required special spot lights and a green screen as backdrop. The installation enabled the audience to take pictures almost in the same quality and colour as the original photographs, giving an illusion that the person was part of the colonial times. For those who gave consent for their pictures to be shared, the pictures were shared on the exhibition Twitter account @thebornfrees. While the intention was to allow people to “be part of the struggle”, the question raised as to what extent it could be offensive to post these kinds of pictures on social media. Yet no negative comment was received and many “fun” photos were taken by the visitors.

Fig. 4: Photographs from the photobooth. © A.P Kambunga

Conclusion

The exhibition presented multiple voices in co-existence on issues relating to postcolonialism's past, present and future in an immersive interactive manner leveraging emerging technologies, such as augmented reality and soundscapes. The co-creation process explored new ways of engaging young people into museum activities and for our Namibian museums to start embracing contemporary digital heritage rather than an authoritarian approach. The exhibition created a deeper understanding of the youth's postcolonial experiences in Namibia. Thus, locating this exhibition in the Independence Memorial Museum, was of utmost significance considering that the Namibian postcolonial youth is shaped by the surrounding representations of the national history.

Acknowledgements

We thank and acknowledge collaboration with Namibian born-frees and students. We thank the Namibia University and Technology, Independence Memorial Museum, Technology Innovation Hub. This project has received funding from the European Union's Horizon 2020 research and innovation programme under the Marie Skłodowska-Curie grant agreement No. 764859.

References

[AsAV18] Ashikoto, L. I., Ajibola, D., & Virmasalo, V. (2018). A room for social justice. *Proceedings of the Second African Conference for Human Computer Interaction on Thriving Communities - AfriCHI 18*. doi: 10.1145/3283458.3283505

[LuBa07] Ciolfi, L., & Bannon, L. J. (2007). Designing hybrid places: merging interaction design, ubiquitous technologies and geographies of the museum space. *CoDesign*, *3*(3), 159–180. doi: 10.1080/15710880701524559

[Beck18] Becker, H. (2018). Changing urbanscapes: Colonial and postcolonial monuments in Windhoek. *Nordic Journal of African Studies*.

[DaDE08] Dalsgaard, P., Dindler, C., & Eriksson, E. (2008). Designing for participation in public knowledge institutions. *Proceedings of the 5th Nordic Conference on Human-Computer Interaction Building Bridges - NordiCHI 08*. doi: 10.1145/1463160.1463171

[KBCB04] Ferris, K., Bannon, L., Ciolfi, L., Gallagher, P., Hall, T., & Lennon, M. (2004). Shaping experiences in the hunt museum. *Proceedings of the 2004 Conference on Designing Interactive Systems Processes, Practices, Methods, and Techniques - DIS 04*. doi: 10.1145/1013115.1013144

[Giac11] Giaccardi, E. (2011). Things we value. *Interactions*, *18*(1), 17. doi: 10.1145/1897239.1897245

[Giac12] Giaccardi, E. (2012). *Heritage and social media: understanding heritage in a participatory culture*. New York, NY: Routledge.

[GuOS13] Gunn, W., Otto, T., & Smith, R. C. (2013). *Design anthropology theory and practice*. London: Bloomsbury.

[SeSm12] Iversen, O. S., & Smith, R. C. (2012). Scandinavian participatory design. *Proceedings of the 11th International Conference on Interaction Design and Children - IDC 12*. doi: 10.1145/2307096.2307109

[KaHS16] Kandjimi, H. Muyingi, H and Sieck, J. 2016. A usability study of indoor micro location-aware interactive guide application in museum: case of Namibian Independence Museum. Conference: XIV. Conference Culture and Computer ScienceAt: Schloss Köpenick, Berlin DE. Retrieved from https://bit.ly/2TwZAEO

[Köss15] Kössler, R. (2015). *Namibia and Germany: negotiating the past*. Windhoek: University of Namibia press.

[Melb19] Melber, H. (2019). Colonialism, Land, Ethnicity, and Class: Namibia after the Second National Land Conference. *Africa Spectrum*, *54*(1), 73–86. doi: 10.1177/0002039719848506

[MuOM14] Muchinenyika, S. H., Weede, O., & Muyingi, H. N. (2014). Persuasive souvenir. *Proceedings of the 13th Participatory Design Conference on Short Papers, Industry Cases, Workshop Descriptions, Doctoral Consortium Papers, and Keynote Abstracts - PDC 14 - Volume 2*. doi: 10.1145/2662155.2662225

[Muco19] Museum Conversations. (2019). Retrieved from https://www.goethe.de/ins/na/en/kul/sup/mus.html

[Saun17] Saunders, C. (2017). Decolonization In Southern Africa: Reflections On The Namibian And South African Cases. *Journal for Contemporary History*, *42*(1). doi: 10.18820/24150509/jch42.v1.6

[Silv15] Silvester, J. (2015). *Re-viewing resistance in Namibian history*. Windhoek: Unam Press.

[Simo10] Simon, N. (2010). *The participatory museum*. California: Museum 2.0.

[SmSe11] Smith, R. C., & Iversen, O. S. (2011). When the museum goes native. *Interactions*, *18*(5), 15. doi: 10.1145/2008176.2008182

[SmIv14] Smith, R. C., & Iversen, O. S. (2014). Participatory heritage innovation: designing dialogic sites of engagement. Digital Creativity, 25(3), 255–268. doi: 10.1080/14626268.2014.904796

[SmOt16] Smith, R. C and Otto, O. 2016. Cultures of the future: Emergence and intervention in design anthropology. Design Anthropological Futures (2016), 19–36.

[SVKO16] Rachel C. Smith, Kasper Tang Vangkilde, Mette Gislev Kjærsgaard, Ton Otto, Joachim Halse, Thomas Binder. 2016. Design Anthropological Futures. Bloomsbury Academic. London.

[WeMM14] Weede, O., Muchinenyika, S. H., & Muyingi, H. N. (2014). Virtual welcome guide for interactive museums. *Proceedings of the 13th Participatory Design Conference on Short Papers, Industry Cases, Workshop Descriptions, Doctoral Consortium Papers, and Keynote Abstracts - PDC 14 - Volume 2*. doi: 10.1145/2662155.2662222

[WiMa19] Williams, C. A., & Mazarire, T. (2019). The Namibian Independence Memorial Museum, Windhoek, Namibia. *The American Historical Review*, *124*(5), 1809–1811. doi: 10.1093/ahr/rhz1163

[WCKB10] Winschiers-Theophilus, H., Chivuno-Kuria, S., Kapuire, G. K., Bidwell, N. J., & Blake, E. (2010). eing participated: a community approach. *Proceedings of the 11th Biennial Participatory Design Conference on - PDC 10*. doi: 10.1145/1900441.1900443

[WiBB12] Winschiers-Theophilus, H., Bidwell, N. J., & Blake, E. (2012). Community Consensus: Design Beyond Participation. *Design Issues*, *28*(3), 89–100. doi: 10.1162/desi_a_00164

[WoBa18] World Bank. 2018. GINI index (World Bank estimate) Retrieved September 1,2018 from https://data.worldbank.org/indicator/si.pov.gini